

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SUNDAY 16 AUGUST 2026 · THE WEEKEND EDITION



THE LANNA CITY BY ITS SEASONS · THE SHOW THAT ATE THE GAME · A NEW DESK THAT READS THE CLOTH, NOT THE LABEL

THE TRAVEL DESK

Chiang Mai, read by its calendar — three hundred temples, a coffee scene to rival its cafés, one glorious lantern night and one month to flee

THE LONG READ

Taiwan turned baseball into a concert — then started importing Korea's idols to headline it. The first market to sell Korean cool back to Seoul

THE RABBIT HOLE

Nobody plans to spend seven thousand dollars on a picture of a lizard. Inside the cardboard economy, where a grade quadruples a price

THIS ISSUE

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FROM THE DESK

"The spectacle is not a collection of images; it is a social relation between people that is mediated by images."

— **Guy Debord**, *The Society of the Spectacle* (1967)¹

The week keeps handing us the sideshow that ate the show. In Taiwan's ballparks the crowd faces the cheer platform, not the pitcher — the game reduced to a pretext for the gathering (p25). In the card world a grade, not the card, is the asset, quadrupling a price with a number in a slab (p15). And a new desk opens by insisting on the opposite discipline — read the cloth, not the label (p6). Debord saw the shape sixty years ago: the thing we gather to watch turns out to be each other, watching.

THE STRIP — AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

LEVEL	14 AUG
S&P 500	7,785
STI	5,743.6
US 10-Year	~4.66%
US 30-Year	5.24%
DXY	99.64
USD/JPY	159.3
Brent	~\$87
Gold (XAU)	\$4,376
Bitcoin	~\$63k

Levels at the Friday 14 Aug US close (15–16 Aug weekend). Arrows vs No. 73. Market data, not advice.

THE WORLD • CENTRAL AFRICA

The Outbreak the World Walked Away From

A rarer Ebola strain, no licensed vaccine, and a war on top of it — the fastest-spreading epidemic on record is unfolding in the near-absence of the donor that used to run point.

The number that matters is not the death toll but its slope. The Ebola epidemic in eastern Democratic Republic of Congo, declared on 15 May and thought to have begun in January, had by mid-August reached roughly 4,665 confirmed cases and 2,184 deaths — a case-fatality rate near forty-seven per cent, and, crucially, the fastest-growing curve any Ebola outbreak has ever traced.¹ On 13 August Africa CDC logged a sixth affected province; the virus has also crossed into Uganda.²

What makes this one different from the 2014–16 West African catastrophe that killed some 11,300 is the strain. This is Bundibugyo ebolavirus — a rarer branch of the family with no licensed vaccine and no approved treatment, only four candidates still in the pipeline.¹ The ring-vaccination playbook that eventually broke earlier outbreaks does not exist here. The World Health Organization's director-general, Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus, says that at the current pace it is on track to become the deadliest in the disease's history, and that the true infection count may run three to four times the confirmed tally.²

47%

CASE-FATALITY RATE AMONG CONFIRMED CASES — A STRAIN WITH NO LICENSED VACCINE

THE DEFUNDING FRAME

CNN • STAT

A containable outbreak became the deadliest on record because Washington dismantled the machinery that fought it — the WHO withdrawal, the winding-down of USAID, the CDC cuts. US funding to DRC fell from about \$1.2bn in FY2024 toward a fraction of that a year on; PPE, cold-chain and testing degraded or never arrived. A preventable disaster authored by donor retreat.³

THE WAR FRAME

WHO • UN, GENEVA

Money is not the binding constraint — the fighting is. The virus spreads through a region of active conflict, attacks on clinics and mass displacement, which makes contact-tracing and isolation nearly impossible. "We cannot build community trust or isolate the sick while bombs are falling," Tedros told reporters. Even a fully funded response cannot be run inside a live war.²

THE SCEPTIC • THE BROKEN DENOMINATOR

"Deadliest in history" is a projection built on numbers everyone agrees are wrong. Forbes reports Congo is counting fewer than half its cases; Tedros himself puts true infections three to four times higher. If so, either this is *already* the largest ever — or the headline fatality rate is badly overstated, because the uncounted cases are the mild ones that never reach a clinic.⁴

— John Drake, Forbes, 4 Aug 2026

SOURCES 1. WHO Disease Outbreak News 2026–DON608 — Bundibugyo ebolavirus, DRC & Uganda; strain, declaration date, no licensed vaccine. 2. The Week (India) & The Columbian, 12–13 Aug 2026 — "set to become deadliest in history"; sixth province; true-count 3–4× (WHO/Tedros). 3. CNN, 22 May 2026, & STAT, 19 May 2026 — US aid cuts and the DRC response. 4. Forbes (J. Drake), 4 Aug 2026 — "Congo Is Counting Fewer Than Half Its Ebola Cases." Tolls as of ~12–13 Aug, developing.

THE WORLD · THE ANNIVERSARY

Five Years On, Kabul Counts What It Kept and What It Lost

Safer streets, residents say — and a cohort of girls now approaching adulthood with their schooling frozen where it stopped.

Kabul fell on 15 August 2021; this weekend marks five years of Taliban rule. The register on the ground, as reporters found it, is double-edged: many residents say they feel physically safer after decades of war, and in the same breath ask for jobs and for the schools to reopen.¹ Girls remain barred from education beyond grade six — a prohibition imposed in September 2021 and extended to universities in December 2022 — which means an entire age band has now spent its formative years locked out of a classroom.¹

The quieter damage is to the boys, too. As the curriculum tilts toward religious instruction and qualified teachers leave, the education system hollows from both ends. No Western government formally recognises the Taliban; regional engagement, led by China, Russia and the Central Asian states, has nonetheless deepened.²

THE CHATTER · THE LONG VIEW

The anniversary coverage this year is less about the fall than about the reckoning of a frozen decade — aid workers and Afghan educators quoted across the wires return to the same figure: the years a child does not get back. The debate among watchers is whether quiet regional recognition now hardens the status quo, or buys leverage to reopen the schools.

Wire and broadcast coverage, 14 Aug 2026

ALSO AROUND THE DESKS

Indonesia — a strong quake offshore. A magnitude-7.7 earthquake struck off the Indonesian coast early Saturday, with early reports of at least 38 dead and buildings down in a tsunami-prone stretch; toll and tsunami status still developing (single-sourced at press time — treat the count as provisional).³

The oil tail. The market story under this weekend's calm is a bid under Brent from an open-ended blockade threat in the Gulf — the same tail the Macro desk reads through gold and the long bond ([p14](#)).

The register, deliberate. A weekend edition leads with life, not the wire — the hard desks run leaner by design, the lifestyle desks longer. Normal service, seasonally adjusted.

The cohort that lost the decade. The girls barred at grade six in 2021 are fifteen and sixteen now — old enough to marry under the regime's reading, too old to have finished a schooling that stopped four years ago. The ban's cost compounds; it does not pause.

THE SCEPTIC · ON ANNIVERSARIES

Five-year markers flatter the observer more than they inform. The honest question is not how Kabul feels in August but whether the frozen grades are a policy that bends or a settlement that sets — and on that, the evidence this week is thin either way.

SOURCES 1. The Washington Post, 14 Aug 2026 — "Afghanistan marks 5 years under the Taliban"; NPR, 14 Aug 2026 — the toll on girls' and boys' education. 2. Regional-recognition context, wire coverage, Aug 2026 (formal recognitions unverified this session — held). 3. Wire morning-briefing aggregation, 15 Aug 2026 — Indonesia M7.7 offshore; single-sourced, awaiting USGS/BNPB confirmation.

SINGAPORE · THE WEEK BEFORE THE RALLY

A Quiet Sunday, and the One Next Week

Before the set-piece, a week to ask what "Go Beyond" will actually mean for the grocery bill, the flat and the childcare fees — when the Prime Minister stands up seven days from now.

The National Day Rally lands next Sunday — 23 August, at ITE College Central in Ang Mo Kio, Lawrence Wong's third as Prime Minister.¹

This is a preview, not a verdict: the reader has a week to decide what he wants to hear. The signalling so far, read off the National Day Message and the months of taskforce language, points at four familiar pressures — the cost of living, housing, jobs in an age of AI disruption, and, notably, a promised review of how the state supports families, with childcare and the cost of raising a child named explicitly.²

The concrete money is already dated. More than 2.4 million citizens will receive a cost-of-living special payment of between S\$400 and S\$600 from 9 September — but the reader-relevant deadline is earlier and duller: link the NRIC to PayNow by 30 August to be paid in the first tranche.³ Eligibility runs on the usual levers: one property or fewer, assessable income for the year up to S\$100,000.³

2.4m

CITIZENS DUE S\$400–600 FROM 9 SEP — LINK PAYNOW–NRIC BY 30 AUG

THE CHATTER · THE GROUND MOOD

The register the Rally walks into is wary. After the Prime Minister teared up at the May Day Rally, one local aggregator caught the ground reaction as admiration for the resilience shadowed by a harder question — whether the emotional key matches a season of rising prices.

The Online Citizen ground round-up, May 2026 — one outlet's read, not a poll

For a household that clears the income bar and owns its flat, the payment is real cash but modest ballast. The structural questions — whether childcare support becomes a recurring mechanism rather than another one-off, whether the housing message reassures or unsettles — are what next Sunday is actually for.⁴

Two threads are worth watching for what they signal about the reader's own decade. On housing, whether the message steadies a market where HDB resale has softened for two quarters while a thin top tier keeps printing million-dollar flats; and on work, whether the AI-and-jobs language becomes a concrete retraining commitment or stays a warning. The Economic Resilience Taskforce is the scaffolding under both, and the National Day Message named the cost of raising children directly — the strongest hint of where the structural money, if any, will go.²

THE READER'S TO-DO

Before 30 August. Link your NRIC to PayNow in the bank app — it is the only thing standing between an eligible household and the earliest 9 September payout. Two minutes; do it this weekend.

THE SCEPTIC · CUSHION VS CURE

A S\$400–600 transfer softens an inflation number; it does not bend one. "Family-support review" has appeared in rally language before without a structural change to childcare costs. The tell to watch on 23 August is the word *recurring* — a mechanism, not another cheque.

SOURCES 1. Mothership; Malay Mail, 13 Jun 2026 — NDR 2026 on 23 Aug at ITE College Central, Ang Mo Kio. 2. PMO National Day Message 2026 — trailed themes (cost of living, housing, jobs/AI, family-support review). 3. MOF newsroom; SupportGoWhere — S\$400–600 cost-of-living special payment, 2.4m citizens, from 9 Sep; PayNow–NRIC by 30 Aug; eligibility. 4. Desk analysis; ground-mood ref: The Online Citizen, May 2026 (single outlet).

THE ATELIER · BUY IT ONCE — NO. 1 · SLEEPWEAR

Read the Momme, Ignore the Adjective

A new desk, and the reader's own question to open it: if you wanted one luxury set of pyjamas, what do people actually lust over? The answer starts at the cloth — and a 28°C bedroom rewrites the order.

Everything on this page is decided before a logo is sewn on. In cotton, the tell is the yarn, not the thread count: two-fold — two fine threads twisted into one before weaving — is the benchmark, and a big count on single-ply is the cheat. Standard poplin runs about 140 threads; only true Egyptian and Sea Island cloth clears 400, and Sea Island is the rare one — under four ten-thousandths of a per cent of world cotton, prized for strength as much as softness.¹ In silk, read the momme, the weight: nineteen momme is airweight and breathes freely but wears out under daily laundering; twenty-two is the durability sweet spot, richer and longer-lived, and warmer.² The construction that separates tiers is visible — mother-of-pearl buttons, contrast piping, side gussets, French seams, and the grail marker, hand-sewn buttonholes that survive the wash.³

<0.0004%

SEA ISLAND'S SHARE OF WORLD COTTON — THE RARITY
YOU'RE PAYING FOR

THE MAKERS, BY TIER

Entry of quality (~S\$230–350). Piglet in Bed linen (~US\$170), Tekla organic poplin (US\$245), Sunspel and Hanro — honest cloth and real weaves, machine seams. The floor is already good.⁴

The sweet spot (~S\$350–700). Zimmerli of Switzerland (from ~US\$260 — its voile is the connoisseur's quiet pick) and Derek Rose's better lines, the Batiste and Filo di Scozia; not every Derek Rose line is cut to the same level.⁴ This is where most buyers should stop.

Bespoke & grail (S\$1,000+). Emma Willis linen from her Gloucester workshop (~US\$800), Turnbull & Asser silk

(£895), Olivia von Halle silk (to ~US\$950), Charvet's Place Vendôme silk, New & Lingwood's dressing gowns — and, tellingly, a bespoke pair from Burgos at about €320.⁴

THE CHATTER · STYLEFORUM & PERMANENT STYLE

The connoisseur's pick on Ask Andy and Styleforum leans Zimmerli voile over Derek Rose — "the quality of the cloth gives an exceptionally nice feel," and the seams "hold up better in the washing machine." On Permanent Style, Simon Crompton's verdict on his commissioned pair is that the grail is fit and the hand-sewn buttonholes, not the label — his bespoke set cost less than a logo silk one.

Ask Andy About Clothes; Styleforum; Permanent Style, 2018–2026

The white-label truth to keep: cloth provenance is not garment provenance. The Italian and Swiss silks and the Egyptian and Sea Island cottons come from a small set of weavers, so two "different" luxury sets can be the same cloth with a different make. What you pay up for at the top is the make and the fit — and, above a point, the name.³

THE SCEPTIC · THE 28°C VERDICT

Two honest cuts. Once a silk set clears about S\$1,000, ask what changed on the *garment* — a monogram and a box are not momme or a felled seam. And for a 28°C bedroom, be blunt: silk is warmer than airweight cotton and needs cold hand-washing, so two-fold Swiss batiste or Irish linen beats it here on comfort, durability *and* care. The tropical buy-once answer is a batiste set with mother-of-pearl buttons — not a monogrammed silk one.

NEXT ON THE BENCH — YOU PICK THE CATEGORY

Audio cables & hi-fi accessories — the sceptic special: real geometry and terminations vs directional-copper theatre.

Chinese woks — carbon steel from the makers up, and why a \$40 pan out-cooks a \$400 one once seasoned.

Watch winders — genuine engineering vs velvet-lined furniture; your rotation may need none.

SOURCES 1. Cotton weave/thread-count primers (Charles Tyrwhitt, Hugh & Crye); Derek Rose — Sea Island cotton (<0.0004%, WISICA). 2. Momme weight guides (Mayfairsilk, SilkSilky) — 19 vs 22 momme breathability/durability. 3. Simon Crompton, "Bespoke pyjamas," PermanentStyle.com — construction tells; cloth-vs-garment provenance. 4. Retailer/maker listings (Aug 2026, via search): Piglet ~US\$170; Tekla US\$245; Zimmerli from US\$260; Emma Willis ~US\$800; Turnbull & Asser £895; Olivia von Halle to ~US\$950; bespoke Burgos €320. S\$ figures approximate conversions, not quoted SG retail; several prices held where unverified.

TECHNOLOGY · THE EXPORT PARADOX

The Chips Are Frozen. The Weights Walk Free.

Washington spent a year building a licence regime to meter advanced silicon into China. The thing that actually matters to a home lab crossed the border anyway — as a download.

Here is the state of the chip war as of this weekend. After the December reversal, Commerce codified H200 sales to China on 13 January — a framework with a twenty-five per cent tariff on advanced AI chips, case-by-case licensing, end-use certificates and a volume cap near a million units; about ten Chinese firms, Alibaba and Tencent and ByteDance among them, were cleared at seventy-five thousand units apiece.¹ And then: nothing shipped. The framework sits in legal limbo, and Beijing separately told its champions not to buy, on security grounds.¹

Meanwhile, entirely unmetered, the open weights kept flowing. Qwen, DeepSeek and GLM ship under permissive licences to anyone with a Hugging Face account, and land on a desk in a spare room with no export officer in the loop.² The sovereignty story the headlines chase is about datacentre silicon frozen at a port. The sovereignty story that touches this reader is the opposite one: the capability arrives regardless, on a single graphics card, licence-free.

The specifics underline the point. The January framework cleared roughly ten Chinese firms at seventy-five thousand chips apiece, under a twenty-five per cent tariff and a volume cap — a lattice of controls built for a shipment that has not happened.¹ Beijing, meanwhile, told its own champions not to buy, citing security, and the market for the metered

good simply did not clear. The open-weights market, subject to none of that machinery, cleared instantly and keeps clearing.²

75,000

CHIPS PER CLEARED CHINESE FIRM ON PAPER — AND, SO FAR, ZERO ACTUALLY SHIPPED

The border that governments can police is the silicon. The border that actually leaks is the model.

THE CHATTER · THE HOME-LAB READ

Across the local-AI boards they keep landing the same joke: the US can keep a hundred-thousand-dollar accelerator out of a Shenzhen datacentre, but not a twenty-eight-billion-parameter model off a hobbyist's SSD. The weights are the leak that no tariff schedule addresses — and for a self-hoster, the only supply chain that has never once been export-controlled.

Local-AI community coverage, Aug 2026
(characterised, not quoted)

THE SCEPTIC · DON'T OVER-READ IT

"Weights walk free" is true until it isn't. Licences can add field-of-use terms, and the frontier labs increasingly gate their best models behind APIs precisely so nothing crosses a border. The open flood is real today; it is a policy choice upstream, not a law of nature.

SOURCES 1. Brookings, "The ball game's over..."; Semiconductors Insight — H200 framework codified 13 Jan 2026 (25% tariff, ~1M cap, ~10 firms at 75k units); shipments in legal limbo, Beijing discouraging purchases. 2. Model-release coverage (Qwen/DeepSeek/GLM), Aug 2026 — permissive-licence open weights distributed via Hugging Face/ModelScope.

THE HOME LAB · TWO DAYS ON

Does the Opus-Chaser Actually Fit One 5090?

The launch was last issue's story. The delta is the reality check — now that people have run Qwen3.8-27B, do the vendor numbers hold, and where does the second card earn its slot?

The model itself is the shape a home lab has been waiting for: 27.78 billion parameters, dense rather than mixture-of-experts, multimodal, a native context window of 262,144 tokens, and an Apache-2.0 licence.¹ The vendor's benchmark sheet is loud — a clean sweep over Meta's Muse Glimmer 30B, and a claim to edge Claude Opus 4.6 on fifteen of nineteen overlapping tests.¹ Read those as what they are: vendor-run evals on vendor-chosen overlaps, two days old, with no independent confirmation yet.²

The number that matters here is VRAM, and the maths is friendly. At a four-bit quantisation the weights sit around sixteen to seventeen gigabytes — comfortable on a single RTX 5090's thirty-two, with real headroom left for the cache.³ The catch is the context: that quarter-million-token window will not co-reside with the weights on one card. A realistic single-5090 working context is nearer thirty-two to sixty-four thousand tokens — the 262K is a spec-sheet number, not a desktop one.³

~16GB

4-BIT WEIGHTS — FITS ONE 5090 (32GB); THE 262K
CONTEXT DOES NOT CO-RESIDE

This is the clean case for the second card. A dual-5090 box, sixty-four gigabytes between them, is

where the interesting options live: run the model at eight-bit for near-lossless quality, or push the context far past the single-card ceiling, or split it tensor-parallel for throughput.³ One more caveat specific to this release — it is multimodal, and feeding it images or video loads a vision encoder and many more tokens, so the lean path on a single card is text-only.

THE SCEPTIC · READ THE BENCHMARK TWICE

"Beats Opus on fifteen of nineteen" is a vendor selecting the overlaps on its own evals — cherry-pickable and contamination-prone until someone independent re-runs it. And the 262K headline hides the desktop truth: once the weights are resident, your usable context is a fraction of the number on the box.

STILL IN THE RACK

The sovereignty tie-back. This is the concrete face of the page opposite — an Opus-adjacent model, Apache-2.0, on one consumer card, with no licence to import ([p7](#)).

The multimodal tax. The vision path is the quiet cost: an image or a video clip loads an encoder and a flood of tokens, so a single-card owner who wants the long context should feed it text and keep the pictures for the second GPU.

What to actually wait for. The number that will settle this is not a vendor sheet but an independent long-context eval on consumer hardware — throughput and quality at 32K, not the headline 262K. Two weeks, not two days.

SOURCES 1. Qwen/Tongyi Lab via latent.space AINews; Kingy.ai — Qwen3.8-27B: 27.78B dense, multimodal, 262K context, Apache-2.0, released 14 Aug 2026; vendor benchmark claims (8/8 vs Muse Glimmer 30B; 15/19 vs Claude Opus 4.6). 2. Medium/Practical LLM Systems — early independent-scrutiny read; no verified independent benchmark at 48h. 3. VRAM budgeting (standard quantisation math, estimates): Q4_K_M ≈16–17GB fits 32GB; full 262K context won't co-reside (~32–64K realistic single-card); dual-5090 (64GB) enables Q8/long-context/tensor-parallel.

THE KIT · THE OBJECT YOU QUEUE FOR

A Pocket Camera With a Twelve-Month Order Book

No pre-order theatre, no wearable gimmick — the Ricoh GR IV is the anti-hype carry, a magnesium snap-shooter so in demand you grow into the wait.

The reader keeps asking for the opposite of a launch: something durable, single-minded, made to carry for a decade. The Ricoh GR IV is that object. A 26-megapixel APS-C sensor behind a fixed 28mm-equivalent f/2.8 prime, in a magnesium-alloy body the size of a deck of cards, with a two-stop built-in neutral-density filter and five-axis stabilisation — the specification of a tool, not a gadget.¹ It costs US\$1,499 for the body; the Monochrome variant, a sensor that shoots only black-and-white, runs US\$2,199.95.²

The peg is not a spec bump but the queue. The GR line has always been a cult, and demand has outrun supply for months — Ricoh's own marketing manager, on the Monochrome, put it plainly: "we've got twelve months of orders."³ Backorders stretch across the big retailers.³ For a reader who shoots Japanese streets and keeps his tools for years, that is not a deterrent; it is the point.

12 mo

OF ORDERS ON THE BOOKS — THE QUEUE IS THE STORY,
NOT A SPEC BUMP

THE CHATTER · OWNERS

On the GR forums and r/RicohGR the refrain is "the ultimate snap shooter" — supreme pocketability, a lens sharper than it has any right to be, images that sing "when it's in focus." The recurring gripe is exactly that hedge: autofocus that owners still call "not great," and software quirks that never quite get fixed.

r/RicohGR; DPReview forums, 2026

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT YOU'RE REALLY BUYING

Fifteen hundred US dollars for a fixed-lens compact with no viewfinder and middling autofocus — and you queue months to pay it. A current phone closes much of the gap for the shared-electronically snap most buyers actually take. This is a want dressed as a tool; buy it knowing which.

STILL ON THE SHELF

Sennheiser Momentum 5 Wireless — US\$399. The value flagship, shipped June: a user-replaceable 700mAh battery (a genuine buy-once virtue), 57 hours of ANC, aptX Lossless, eight-mic noise cancelling. The headphone that ages gracefully rather than dying with its cell.⁴

Sony 1000X "The ColleXion" — US\$649.99. A tenth-anniversary luxe edition of the ANC benchmark. Handsome; also, as one outlet put it, "the anniversary headphones most people won't buy."⁴

57h

ANC BATTERY ON THE MOMENTUM 5 — AND A CELL YOU
CAN REPLACE, NOT A CLOCK YOU CAN'T STOP

The buy-once tell, generalised. The through-line of this fortnight's gear is repairability over spec-sheet drama — a replaceable battery, a metal body, a single great lens. The object that survives a decade beats the one that wins a launch.

SOURCES 1. DPReview — Ricoh GR IV in-depth review (26MP APS-C, 28mm-eq f/2.8, magnesium, 2EV ND, 5-axis IS). 2. TechRadar; Adorama/B&H listings — GR IV US\$1,499; GR IV Monochrome US\$2,199.95. 3. TechRadar — "twelve months of orders" (Ricoch EMEA); retailer backorders. Base body shipped Q4 2025; the 2026 peg is sustained scarcity + the Monochrome. \$\$ price not a verified local RRP — held. 4. SoundGuys; PRNewswire — Sennheiser Momentum 5 (US\$399, replaceable battery, 57h ANC, aptX Lossless); Sony 1000X "ColleXion" (US\$649.99).

THE GOOD LIFE · THE ESCAPE

A Venetian Legend Gets New Keys

The Danieli — a Gothic palazzo on the lagoon since the fourteenth century — reopens under Four Seasons, its pink-marble atrium and gilded staircase intact, its nightly rate pointedly unpublished.

Some hotels are buildings; the Danieli is an institution, and this summer it changed hands. The fourteenth-century palazzo on Riva degli Schiavoni — a few steps from St Mark's and the Doge's Palace, its windows on the lagoon — has reopened as the Danieli, a Four Seasons Hotel, after a US\$34-million restoration led by the French designer Pierre-Yves Rochon. It is Four Seasons' fourth address in Italy.¹ The signatures were kept: the four-storey atrium with its pink-marble columns, the gilded staircase, the Murano chandeliers, the terrazzo floors.¹

The details worth holding lightly are the ones the sources disagree on. The hotel opens with about 120 rooms and suites, growing toward the high 160s once the Palazzo Danieli Excelsior wing is restored in 2027; the spa, three treatment rooms with sauna and hammam, arrives late this year.² Even the opening date splits — reported both as "now open" and as 26 August — though bookings are already live.³ The nightly rate, tellingly, is nowhere published, and this desk will hold it rather than invent one.²

A legend reborn is the trade press's favourite phrase — and its favourite thing to get wrong.

US\$34m

THE RESTORATION BEHIND THE REOPENING — 120 KEYS AT OPEN, THE RATE STILL UNPUBLISHED

THE CHATTER · THE WATCHERS

FlyerTalk's luxury-hotels thread has run hot on the reopening for months; the travel trade has it filed as one of the most-watched European openings of the year — a legend reborn under a stewardship that rarely fumbles a marquee property.

FlyerTalk luxury-hotels forum, 2026

THE SCEPTIC · PATINA IS NOT REFRESHABLE

A "design refresh" of a hotel this storied risks sanding centuries of patina into corporate-luxe uniformity — and you are buying into peak-Venice overtourism with only 120 keys open, the spa and the full room count still months away. The Danieli's magic was never its newness. Wait for the wing, and for a rate.

Context matters for how this reads. It is the fourth Four Seasons in Italy and the group's most storied conversion yet — Rochon is the designer behind some of the marque's grandest rooms, which is either reassurance or the exact worry, depending on how much you prize a hotel's accumulated wear. The Danieli has hosted Dickens and Wagner and Proust; a restoration that flatters the ledger and flattens the ghosts would be the quiet loss.¹

ALSO IN THE COLUMN

The honest counter. The most romantic room in Venice still opens onto the most crowded square in Europe. For a quieter splurge with a craft-and-coffee bent, the weekend's Grand Tour points inland and east ([p21](#)).

SOURCES 1. Euronews Travel, 31 Jul 2026 — Danieli reopens as a Four Seasons after a US\$34M Pierre-Yves Rochon restoration; preserved atrium/staircase/chandeliers; 4th Four Seasons in Italy. 2. IndexBox; Connecting Travel — ~120 rooms at open growing toward ~168–176 by 2027 (sources differ); Danieli Spa late 2026; nightly rate unpublished (held). 3. Opening date reported as "now open" (Euronews) and 26 Aug (IndexBox/OneMileAtATime) — discrepancy flagged; bookings open.

SCREEN & SOUND · THE RECORD FOR THE ROOM

Jungle Make the Sundown Album Again

The British funk-soul collective's fifth, "Sunshine," is a no-skips groove record engineered for good speakers — and a small argument about the cost of a winning formula.

"Sunshine," Jungle's fifth album, landed on 14 August — a groove-heavy, warm-analogue set built for exactly the kind of system this reader owns.¹ The early critical read is kind but thin: an aggregate score around 80, on only a handful of reviews, which is a signal, not a verdict.² On its first day it drew some 11.5 million Spotify listeners — respectable, well behind the week's pop juggernaut but very much the connoisseur's pick of the Friday.³ Put it on, dim the lights, let the room warm up.

The counter-programming was loud. KATSEYE's "Wild" dominated the streaming Friday at more than 35 million first-day listeners — the pop story of the week — while The Script returned with "The User's Guide to Being Human."³ None of them is the record you demo the speakers with; Jungle is.

THE CHATTER · FANS & CRITICS

The positive camp calls "Sunshine" a "no-skips" record that's "impossible to sit still to" — vintage Jungle warmth, the sound of a band comfortable in its lane. The dinner-table debate is whether that comfort is the point or the problem.

Album-of-the-Year reviews aggregate, Aug 2026

THE SCEPTIC · FORMULA FATIGUE

The dissent is sharp: one review rated it two out of five and argued that "sticking to what Jungle perceives as a winning formula is the death knell for Sunshine." A fifth album that sounds like the first four is a pleasure the first time and a rut the fifth.²

If the record for the room is Jungle, the record for the charts belongs elsewhere. KATSEYE's "Wild" was the streaming event of the Friday, and the pop machinery around it makes the funk album's eleven million listeners look almost artisanal by contrast — two different definitions of a hit, released the same day.³ The reader's system was built for one of them.

AT THE PICTURES

The guilt-free outing — PAW Patrol: The Dino Movie.

Paramount's wide family release (14 Aug) is the bright, low-stakes counter-programming for the school-holiday crowd, and the one film you can take an eleven-year-old to while the internet argues about the grown-up hit. Scores too early to call.⁴

Next week's adult pick — The Rivals of Amziah King.

Matthew McConaughey's crime thriller opens limited this weekend and wide on 21 August; hold the reviews until it lands.⁴

The weekend's actual monster. The grown-up hit topping the box office is the one this desk covered last issue and won't re-run; the point of the picks above is what to do with the family while the internet argues about it.

SOURCES 1. Official Charts New Music Friday; AlbumOfTheYear — Jungle, "Sunshine" (5th album), released 14 Aug 2026. 2. AlbumOfTheYear — critic aggregate ~80 on ~6 reviews (early/low-volume, flagged); dissenting 2/5 review ("winning formula... the death knell"). 3. DraftKings Network New Music Friday radar — first-day Spotify: Jungle ~11.5M; KATSEYE "Wild" ~35.3M; The Script also out. 4. Box Office Mojo; DIRECTV Insider — PAW Patrol: The Dino Movie (Paramount, wide 14 Aug); The Rivals of Amziah King (limited 14 Aug, wide 21 Aug). Scores too early — not invented.

THE FAMILY DESK · THE REFRAME

It Was Never the Hours

The 2026 evidence quietly retired the stopwatch. The damage screens do runs mostly through two things they push out — movement and sleep — and those are the two a parent can actually guard.

For a decade the screen debate has been an argument about a number: how many hours is too many. A large 2026 analysis of American children suggests the number was the wrong thing to count. Drawing on the National Survey of Children's Health — 50,231 children aged six to seventeen — it found the familiar alarming associations: kids logging four or more hours a day of recreational screen time carried markedly higher rates of anxiety, depression and conduct problems than lighter users.¹ The depression association was the largest.

But the study's real contribution was to ask where the harm travels. Its mediation model pointed to two pathways doing most of the work: physical activity displaced, and sleep disrupted. Screens, on this reading, are least dangerous as pixels and most dangerous as a thief of the run-around hour and the bedtime.¹ The mechanism is almost boring in how actionable it is.

50,231

US CHILDREN IN THE 2026 COHORT — ASSOCIATIONS, NOT PROOF OF CAUSE

Institutions have already moved. In January 2026 the American Academy of Pediatrics retired its long-standing hour-based guidance in favour of a framework that asks a single question — *what is the screen displacing?* — and keeps two hard rules: no devices in the bedroom, and no screens in the hour

before sleep.² It is the clinical version of the same finding.

THE CHATTER · PARENT FORUMS

On r/parenting and Singapore's KiasuParents boards the mood is relief mixed with fatigue: parents are glad the story moved from "screens rot the brain" to "protect sleep and play," which feels doable rather than damning. The two rules people say actually hold are the device-free bedroom and the no-phone dinner.

Synthesised from parent-forum discourse, Aug 2026

One distinctly local wrinkle runs through the Singapore threads: for a PSLE-track household, a tween's "screen time" is increasingly a tuition app and a homework portal, not a game. A blanket daily cap treats those minutes the same as doom-scrolling. The displacement lens — guard the bedtime, bank the movement — survives that objection where a stopwatch does not.

THE SCEPTIC · DON'T BE ALARMIST

The causal story is thin. A separate three-year study of roughly 25,000 adolescents found no direct causal path from social-media use to later anxiety or depression, and the cross-sectional effect sizes elsewhere are small and vulnerable to reverse causation — anxious children retreat to screens as much as screens unsettle children.³

Read the scary percentages as a flag to look closer at your own child's sleep and activity, not as a verdict delivered on her.

SOURCES 1. *Humanities & Social Sciences Communications* (Nature portfolio), 2026 — screen time, physical activity and sleep as parallel mediators of child mental-health associations; NSCH cohort n=50,231. 2. American Academy of Pediatrics — Jan 2026 revision replacing hour-based limits with a displacement/quality framework (device-free bedrooms; no screens the hour before bed). 3. *Journal of Public Health* — three-year cohort (~25,000, ages 11–14) finding no direct causal social-media → depression link; reverse-causation caveat. General guidance, not medical advice; all figures observational.

THE FAMILY DESK · THE PROTOCOL

Two Levers, Both in Your Hands

If the harm runs through displaced movement and lost sleep, the intervention is a household routine — not a confiscation.

The comfort of the displacement finding is that it hands a parent two levers that need no willpower war over the device itself. The first is the bedroom. The single rule with the best evidence behind it — echoed by the paediatric reframe — is that the phone charges outside the bedroom overnight, and the last hour before sleep is screen-free.¹ It removes the 1 a.m. group chat and the blue-lit scroll in one move, and it does not require reading anyone's messages.

The second is movement, and it is where this desk hands off to the next one. An eleven-year-old who has a daily physical outlet — a sport, a bike, a pool, an hour outdoors — has the protective pathway topped up regardless of what the screen total reads that day.² The point is not to shrink the screen number; it is to make sure the two things it competes with win the schedule first.

WHERE THE HARM TRAVELS

The study's mediation model, largest pathway first



Ordering illustrative of the 2026 mediation analysis; magnitudes approximate. Meridian original

The pathways that carry the screen-mood association, ordered by weight — movement first.

Why the bedroom rule earns its place is worth spelling out. A phone on the nightstand is not one distraction but three — the blue-lit scroll that pushes back sleep onset, the group chat that pulls a child out of it at midnight, and the alarm-clock excuse that keeps the whole apparatus in reach. Charging it in the hall removes all three at once, and it does so without a single argument about screen minutes or a parent reading anyone's messages.¹ The lever is architectural, not disciplinary.

None of this is a diagnosis, and the honest ceiling on the claim is worth keeping in view: this is observational data, drawn largely from cross-sections, and it describes populations, not your daughter at her desk.³ What it licenses is modest and useful — a routine, not a panic.

ALSO ON THE DESK

The AAP's quiet pivot. The move from "two hours" to "what is it displacing?" is the biggest change to the standard advice in fifteen years — and it lowers the guilt without lowering the guardrails.

Not all minutes are equal. A maths-practice app and an infinite feed both count as "screen time"; only one of them is the problem the data is pointing at.

Bank strength early. The movement lever pays a second dividend the reader will recognise from the next page — capacities are far easier to keep than to rebuild ([p18](#)).

SOURCES 1. American Academy of Pediatrics, Jan 2026 framework — device-free bedrooms, no screens the hour before sleep. 2. *Humanities & Social Sciences Communications* 2026 — physical activity as the leading mediating pathway; NSCH cohort. 3. Observational, cross-sectional evidence — associations not causation; reverse causation plausible. General guidance for parents, not medical advice.

THE MACRO DESK • THE REGIME

Goldilocks, With an Oil Tail

A record within reach on Wall Street, gold at a fresh high, and a long bond that refuses to fall — three things that should not all be true at once, reconciled by a barrel.

S&P 500 7,785	US 30Y 5.24%	GOLD \$4,376	BRENT ~\$87	BITCOIN ~\$63k
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Start with the barrel, because everything else hangs off it. An open-ended blockade threat in the Gulf keeps Brent bid in the high-eighties, and that single fact keeps inflation expectations sticky and pins the long end of the US curve — the thirty-year near a twenty-five-year high around 5.24 per cent, the ten-year at 4.66 — even though the week's inflation print came in line and the labour data softened.¹ Because those readings trimmed the case for another hike, the dollar eased rather than firmed: the index near 99.6, the yen still weak at 159 and change.²

That pairing — high long-end yields with a soft dollar — is the unusual part, and gold walked straight into the gap, printing a fresh record just north of US\$4,375 as the twin hedge against the oil-inflation tail and a debasing dollar.³ Equities simply climbed the wall: the S&P a whisker off its record and a third straight weekly gain, the Straits Times index firm at 5,743.¹ Bitcoin, notably, sat the haven rally out — rangebound near US\$63,000, decoupled from gold's bid.³

5.24%

US 30-YEAR YIELD — NEAR A 25-YEAR HIGH, EVEN AS THE HIKE BET FADES. THE BOND MARKET'S TELL.

\$4,376

GOLD — A FRESH RECORD; THE REGIME'S CLEAREST WINNER

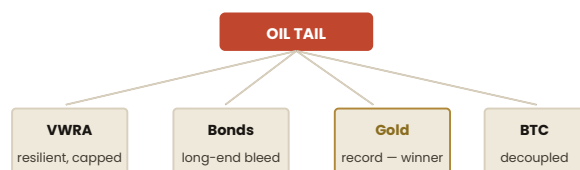
The read across the four instruments, then: global equities resilient near highs but capped by the oil-inflation tail; global bonds still bleeding at the long end under higher-for-longer; gold the clear standout, a record on the dual hedge; bitcoin rangebound and, for now, off gold's script. None of that is a recommendation — it is the weather report.³

THE CHATTER • ASIAN DESKS AT THE CLOSE

Friday's tone read as relief — an in-line US inflation print plus softer labour data "tempered expectations for further tightening," lifting the STI and holding the S&P near its record. The split on the tape: curve-watchers say the 30-year's altitude is term premium, fiscal supply and the oil shock, not Fed policy; the equity bulls point at a third weekly gain as proof the market can climb the oil wall.

Friday market reviews, 14 Aug 2026

ONE FORCE, FOUR READINGS



The same oil-fed, higher-for-longer regime prices each line differently.

Meridian original. Market explanation, not investment advice.

How one driver reads through four instruments this week.

THE SCEPTIC • NOT ACTUALLY GOLDILOCKS

Gold at a record *and* the long bond at a twenty-five-year-high yield, at the same time, is not a soft landing — it is the bond market pricing a fiscal-inflation problem the equity index is choosing to ignore. An "indefinite" blockade is an open-ended call on oil, and one bad barrel breaks the in-line-CPI calm.

SOURCES 1. Yahoo Finance live & CNBC "Stock Market Today," 13–14 Aug 2026 — S&P 7,785 (third weekly gain); Treasury 10Y 4.661%/30Y 5.237%; BusinessToday — STI 5,743.59 (+0.41%). 2. Trading Economics — DXY 99.64 (–0.33%); USD/JPY 159.30. 3. Trading Economics/Fortune — gold \$4,375.50 (+0.60%, record); Brent ~\$87 vs WTI ~\$81.5; CoinGecko — BTC ~\$63k. Levels at Friday 14 Aug close (15–16 Aug weekend). Market explanation, not investment advice; forecasts flagged as such.

THE RABBIT HOLE • THE INVITATION

The Cardboard Economy

Nobody plans to spend seven thousand dollars on a picture of a lizard. It starts with a pack — and two tribes who would never share a lunch table end up buying from the same auction house.

You peel the foil, fan eleven cards, and one is shinier than the rest. That dopamine hit — the "chase" — is the whole hobby in miniature, and it works identically whether the shiny thing is a holographic Charizard or a rookie's first autograph. For a reader in his forties the on-ramp is one of three doors: ripping a pack with your kid, who already knows every Eeveelution by name; the childhood return, when the cards you binned in 1999 now cost a car; or the chase, when you see one card and decide you must own the best copy on earth. Pokémon and baseball are two nations that would never mix — yet they buy from the same houses, argue about the same graders, and hunt the same feeling.

This is not a niche. The global sports-card market was about US\$13.5 billion in 2025 and is tracked toward US\$14.5 billion in 2026; the wider trading-card-game market sits near US\$15 billion.¹ To see how industrial it became: PSA, the dominant grader, slabbed 19.26 million cards in 2025 alone, and at the peak of the 2020–21 mania it was taking in over half a million cards a week, building a twelve-million-card backlog that forced it to suspend its cheap tiers.²

The communities are vast in their own right — the two big Pokémon subreddits run to roughly 1.4 million and 354,000 members — and Fanatics' collectibles arm did around US\$5 billion of a US\$13 billion company in 2025.³ This is a liquid, buy-once-

cry-once market with a genuine high end and, at the very top, the most expensive small rectangle in history.

The scoreboard still measures runs. The box office now measures follower counts — and the card, sometimes, measures more than the player.

19.26m

CARDS GRADED BY PSA IN 2025 ALONE — AN INDUSTRIAL HOBBY

THE CHATTER • WHERE IT STARTS

The subreddits agree the gateway is almost never an investment thesis — it is nostalgia and a child. r/PokemonTCG is broadly welcoming and allergic to "investors"; the return-to-the-hobby posts, mid-forties dads reopening a shoebox, are its most-upvoted genre. The money comes later, and quietly.

r/PokemonTCG (~1.4M), 2026

THE NUMBERS THAT HOOK YOU

US\$16.492M — the Pikachu Illustrator (PSA 10), the most expensive trading card ever, Goldin, February 2026.⁴

124 of 4,993 — first-edition Base Set Charizards ever to earn a PSA 10; scarcity is the whole story.⁵

~8.88% — the share of all PSA submissions that come back Gem Mint 10.²

SOURCES 1. Fortune Business Insights; Mordor Intelligence — sports-card market ~US\$13.5bn (2025) — ~US\$14.5bn (2026); TCG market ~US\$15bn. 2. CardGrade.io — PSA graded 19.26M cards in 2025; ~8.88% gem rate; Yahoo Sports — 500k/week & 12M backlog (2021). 3. GummySearch — r/PokemonTCG ~1.4M, r/PokeInvesting ~354k; Sacra/Fanatics — ~US\$5bn collectibles of ~US\$13bn (2025). 4. Guinness World Records; Goldin — Pikachu Illustrator PSA 10, US\$16.492M, 16 Feb 2026. 5. PokemonPriceTracker — 124 of 4,993 first-edition Charizards graded PSA 10.

THE RABBIT HOLE • THE COMMUNITY & THE CHASE

The Map, and the Cards Worth Hunting

Every card has two prices — one raw, one slabbed — and every tribe has a town square. Learn both before you spend.

The community map first. r/PokemonTCG is the town square, welcoming and anti-speculator; r/PokeInvesting is the trading floor the others mock, its house thesis — that sealed boxes beat the S&P — profiled by *Fortune* and rebutted everywhere else as greater-fool territory.¹ Elite Fourum is the museum wing, WOTC-era purists arguing shadowless-versus-unlimited print variants and centring to the millimetre.¹ On the sports side, r/baseballcards is pulls and prospecting hope while Blowout Forums is the veteran hardcore. And Whatnot — live-breaking on camera, viewers buying "spots" — is the fastest-growing venue and the most contested.²

Now the chase, which is where the buy-once instinct meets the wall. The Pokémon benchmark is the 1999 Base Set Charizard: an unlimited PSA 10 runs roughly US\$4,000–7,000, a shadowless PSA 10 climbs to US\$25,000–40,000, and a first-edition holo PSA 10 is a US\$300,000-plus object, with one realising US\$954,800 at Goldin in February.³ The modern chase is the January-2025 Prismatic Evolutions set, whose Umbreon "special illustration rare" sits near US\$1,500 raw and US\$5,400 in a PSA 10 — the whole grading economy in a single card.⁴

Baseball runs two lanes. The prospecting lane is Bowman Chrome, where a player's "1st Bowman" card is a bet on a future star. The vintage canon is the ceiling: a T206 Honus Wagner traded privately at US\$7.25 million, a lower grade at US\$1.98 million last year; a 1952 Topps Mantle brought US\$12.6 million.⁵ Where you actually buy sorts by ambition — the local

shop and TCGplayer for singles, eBay for depth, and the auction houses (Goldin, Heritage, and the Fanatics-owned PWCC and Fanatics Collect) for anything four figures and up.²

Underneath every purchase sits the hobby's oldest fight: sealed versus singles. Sealed product — boxes, elite trainer boxes — is the lottery ticket and the nostalgia hit; you are buying the rip and the hope of a graded pull, and hoarders bet that scarcity will do the rest. Singles are the sniper's game: buy exactly the card you want in exactly the grade you want, skip the gamble, pay the premium for certainty. Neither camp has ever conceded, and the buy-once reader belongs, quietly, with the snipers.

THE CHATTER • TWO TRIBES

Where Reddit sees "a Charizard," Elite Fourum sees a shadowless print variant and argues centring like a jeweller. And baseball's running argument in 2026 is "Junk Wax 2.0" — that Topps and Fanatics are printing the modern market into worthlessness. Two hobbies, one shared anxiety about scarcity.

Elite Fourum; Blowout Forums; r/baseballcards, 2026

THE SCEPTIC • THE CASINO FLOOR

The fastest-growing venue is legally contested. A July-2025 lawsuit and a spring arbitration by an attorney representing some seventy customers accuse Whatnot and Fanatics Live of running "unregulated gambling" — pay-for-a-spot breaks with seller-skewed odds. Whatnot "absolutely rejects" the framing and says gambling isn't allowed. Buy the card you love, not the ticket you'll flip.²

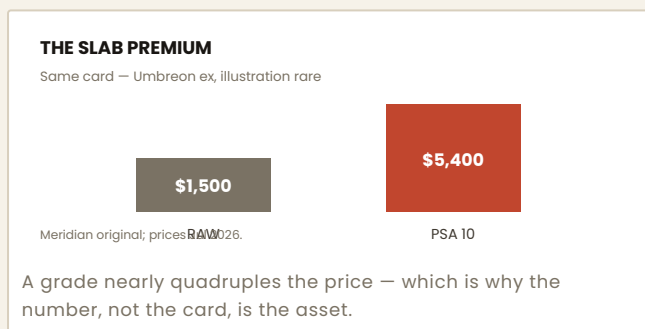
SOURCES 1. *Fortune*, 12 Jul 2025 (r/PokeInvesting thesis); GummySearch; Elite Fourum/PokeGym history. 2. *SI.com*; *ESPN*; *Baseball America* — Whatnot/Fanatics Live lawsuit (Jul 2025) & arbitration; Fanatics ownership of PWCC/Fanatics Collect. 3. *PokemonPriceTracker*; Goldin — Base Charizard PSA 10: unlimited US\$4–7k, shadowless US\$25–40k, 1st-ed US\$300k+ (US\$954,800, Feb 2026). 4. *The Hobby Bin*; *PokeScope* — Umbreon ex SIR: raw ~US\$1,500, PSA 10 ~US\$5,400 (Jul 2026); Prismatic Evolutions released 17 Jan 2025. 5. Beckett; *CBS Sports*; *Heritage* — T206 Wagner US\$7.25M private / US\$1.98M (Apr 2025); 1952 Topps Mantle US\$12.6M.

THE RABBIT HOLE · GRADING, MONEY & THE WAY IN

The Slab Is the Whole Economy

A raw card is an opinion; a slab is a number the market prices off. Everything — the grails, the crash, the way in from Singapore — runs through the grade.

Grading is not a sidebar; it is the economy. The same Umbreon leaps from about US\$1,500 raw to US\$5,400 in a PSA 10, and PSA — roughly two-thirds of Pokémon grading — sets the price with its red label.¹ Its 2026 tiers run from a Regular service at US\$79.99 (its cheapest public "value" tier was paused for demand) up to Premium at US\$999 and beyond; Beckett grades from about US\$25 with four free sub-grades, and CGC is the value pick for cards at around US\$17 bulk.² The disruptor is TAG — computer-vision grading with a digital report — which grew about 40 per cent this year, though a TAG 10 still trades ten to fifteen per cent under a PSA 10.³ The load-bearing check on the whole system is that Fanatics owns Topps, PWCC and Fanatics Collect but not PSA; the grade stays independent.¹



The way in, honestly. Spend the first month lurking — read a pop report, pull a comp on TCGplayer — before buying anything; then buy one rip and one

single to feel both doctrines; then, weeks nine to twelve, buy a single "keeper" slab and submit one raw card yourself to learn the pipeline. A realistic learn-the-hobby budget without the grail is roughly US\$300–600.⁴ And from Singapore you cannot submit to PSA directly — you go through a middleman such as Oxley Grading or Mana Pro, adding perhaps S\$20–30 a card and months to the wait.⁵

THE SCEPTIC · SLABBED CARDBOARD IS NOT AN ASSET CLASS

Two hard truths. The 2020–21 bubble is the cautionary tale — PSA drowning, then a broad cooldown. And modern is not scarce: manufacturers pushed over 429 million NBA cards in a season, "Junk Wax 2.0," with blue-chip base rookies softening 30–40 per cent year over year. One base card in the 1990s; one base card plus forty parallels now. Print is the enemy of the collector.⁶

~8.88%

OF ALL PSA SUBMISSIONS COME BACK GEM MINT 10 — THE NUMBER THE MARKET PRICES OFF

THE GLOSSARY (LEARN THESE FIRST)

Slab graded case · **Gem Mint** a perfect 10 · **Pop** how many exist at that grade · **Comp** a recent comparable sale · **Break** a box opened live, sold as spots · **Hit** the good pull · **Chase** the card you hunt · **Whale** a market-moving spender · **PC** personal collection, not for sale · **Raw** ungraded.

NEXT DESCENTS — YOU PICK TOMORROW'S RABBIT HOLE

Home espresso — the upgrade treadmill made caffeinated: grinders that outprice the machine, and the Singapore café-culture tie-in.

Mechanical keyboards — group-buy economics, endgame culture, and a switch-and-keycap meta that never sits still.

Headphone enthusiasts — IEMs and over-ears, the measurement-vs-ears wars, and a grail ladder that runs into five figures.

SOURCES 1. CardGrade.io — PSA ~67% Pokémon share; grade value-jump (raw ~\$1,500 → PSA 10 ~\$5,400); Fanatics owns Topps/PWCC/Fanatics Collect, not PSA. 2. DKNetwork/CardGrade.io — PSA 2026 tiers (Regular US\$79.99 → Premium US\$999+, value tier paused); BGS ~US\$25 (sub-grades); CGC ~US\$17 bulk. 3. CardGrade.io — TAG computer grading ~40% YoY; TAG 10 ~10–15% under PSA 10. 4. Starter path/budget — indicative 2026 prices (this desk). 5. tcgTalk; Mana Pro — Singapore submission via Oxley/Mana Pro middlemen (+S\$20–30/card + shipping; months at value tiers). 6. Yahoo Sports — "Junk Wax 2.0": 429M NBA cards, base rookies ~30–40% YoY; 2020–21 bubble cooldown.

FITNESS · THE SECOND AXIS

Two Thirty-Second Tests, Read for Decades

The longevity crowd obsesses over aerobic fitness. A 2026 cohort makes the quiet case for the other axis — raw strength — and hands you two free home benchmarks to track it.

Everyone chases VO2 max. A study published in *JAMA Network Open* in February makes the case for what it sits beside. Following more than 5,400 women aged 63 to 99 for about eight years, it found that grip strength and the speed of standing up out of a chair each tracked mortality hard — and, crucially, independent of how much aerobic exercise the women did.¹ You cannot out-run a weak grip.

The numbers: roughly 15 per cent lower all-cause mortality for every seven-kilogram increase in grip, with the strongest group a third less likely to die than the weakest; and about 9 per cent lower per six-second improvement in a sit-to-stand test, the fastest group down 37 per cent.¹ It rhymes with the big international PURE cohort a decade ago, where each five-kilogram drop in grip carried a 16 per cent rise in mortality — grip out-predicting systolic blood pressure.²

33%

LOWER ALL-CAUSE MORTALITY, STRONGEST GRIP VS
WEAKEST — INDEPENDENT OF CARDIO

The practical part is cheap. Buy a hand dynamometer for a number your Oura and Whoop will never give you, and train it with dead hangs, farmer's carries and heavy rows. Run the thirty-second chair-stand test — how many times you can rise, arms crossed — and train it with weighted sit-to-stands and step-ups. Treat strength as a second longevity axis alongside the aerobic one, and bank it now, in your

forties, when it is far easier to build than to rebuild at seventy.³

THE CHATTER · LONGEVITY DISCOURSE

In the Attia-Huberman orbit and on *r/longevity*, grip and the sit-to-stand are beloved precisely because they are free, quantifiable and improvable — the anti-supplement move. The running argument is whether grip is a lever you pull to live longer or merely a dashboard light reading out a vitality you can't fake by squeezing a gripper. The consensus: train full-body strength and grip follows; don't chase the number alone.

r/longevity; longevity-podcast orbit, 2026

THE PROTOCOL, IN TWO MOVES

Grip. Benchmark with a cheap dynamometer for a number nothing on your wrist will give you; train it with accumulated dead hangs (aim sixty to a hundred and twenty seconds), heavy carries and rows. It rides along with any serious pulling work.

The chair-stand. Count your rises in thirty seconds, arms crossed, and re-test monthly; train with weighted sit-to-stands, split squats and step-ups. Both tests cost nothing and both, unusually, are things you can actually move.

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT IT DOESN'T PROVE

This is an association in older women, not a mid-forties trial. Grip is best read as a marker of overall robustness, and the arrow is muddy — subclinical disease saps strength before it kills, so weak grip may be a symptom, not the cause. No trial has shown isolated grip training adds years. Build whole-body strength; don't mistake a firm handshake for an anti-ageing drug. Not medical advice.

SOURCES 1. *JAMA Network Open*, Feb 2026 (LaMonte et al., Women's Health Initiative) — women 63–99, n=5,400, ~8-yr follow-up; grip -15%/7kg (top group -33%); chair-stand -9%/6s (fastest -37%); independent of aerobic activity. 2. Leong et al., *Lancet* 2015 (PURE) — each 5kg grip loss ≈ +16% all-cause mortality; grip beat systolic BP as a predictor. 3. Home tests: hand dynamometer + 30-second sit-to-stand; train via dead hangs, loaded carries, weighted sit-to-stands. General guidance, not medical advice; observational data — association, not causation.

THE TRAVEL DESK • DEPARTURES

What Changed at the Gate

A new balance floor on your miles, more Scoot metal to the north — and the one nonstop that makes this weekend's Grand Tour a three-hour hop.

Start with the miles, because it is the change that will surprise you at the worst moment. Since 21 July, KrisFlyer accounts holding fewer than a thousand miles are blocked from searching award availability on singaporeair.com — the calendar returns an error where space used to appear.¹ It is a search gate, not a booking gate; you still don't need miles to cover a seat, and Singapore Airlines frames the move as swatting the bots that feed award-alert tools.¹ The early workaround is almost comic: the mobile app still returns space for a zero-balance account, so the wall is a fence with an open side gate.¹

The happier delta is lift. Scoot is phasing in Chiang Rai, Okinawa and Tokyo-Haneda across this winter, and from August is thickening the workhorses — Bangkok to 39 weekly flights, Penang to 28.² The line that matters for the pages ahead: Scoot is the only carrier flying nonstop from Singapore to Chiang Mai, about three hours up, which is what turns this weekend's Grand Tour from an expedition into a long lie-in.²

KRISFLYER FLOOR	SCOOT BKK/WK	SIN-CNX
1,000	35 → 39	~3h05

THE CHATTER • THE POINTS DESKS

Reaction on the miles forums skews irritated-but-shrugging: the consensus is that anyone with a genuine balance, or who simply books through the app, is unaffected — it is the award-tool users and the transfer-at-redemption crowd who are stung.

Mainly Miles; The MileLion; One Mile at a Time, Jul 2026

The Scoot build-out is worth reading as more than a timetable. A thicker Bangkok and a resumed Haneda give a Singapore flyer redundancy — a missed connection has an alternative a few hours later — and the added Chiang Rai and Okinawa dots quietly widen the weekend-trip map north. For a household that plans around school holidays, frequency is the underrated luxury; it is what turns a destination from an expedition into an option.²

ALSO AT THE GATE

Changi T5 — steel in the ground. Construction has run since May 2025; Phase 1 targets about 50 million passengers a year in the mid-2030s, with an integrated rail-and-bus ground-transport centre. No fresh milestone this month — file it under "still on track."³

The RTS Link — counting down. The Johor Bahru–Singapore rapid-transit shuttle is still tracking to a end-2026 target; a five-minute crossing that will reset the weekend-across-the-Causeway maths when it opens.³

The green-season dividend. The same calendar that keeps Chiang Mai cheap this month (p21) keeps regional fares soft into the shoulder — the quiet reward for travelling against the crowd.

28

SCOOT'S WEEKLY PENANG FLIGHTS FROM AUGUST, UP FROM 21 — THE SHORT-HAUL GRID THICKENS

NEW ROUTE

POINTS

ENTRY RULES

SOURCES 1. Mainly Miles (28 Jul 2026); The MileLion (21 & 24 Jul 2026) — KrisFlyer minimum 1,000-mile balance to search award space; app workaround; SIA's anti-bot framing. 2. Travel Weekly Asia; Aviation A2Z (27 Jul 2026) — Scoot 2026 network (Chiang Rai/Okinawa/Haneda phasing in); BKK 35 → 39, Penang 21 → 28 weekly (Aug 2026); Scoot the sole nonstop SIN-CNX (frequency indicative). Fares held indicative, not printed. 3. MOT Singapore; Changi Airport Group — T5 from May 2025, Phase 1 ~50M pax mid-2030s; RTS Link end-2026 target.

DEPARTURES · THE RULEBOOK

Japan's November Switch, and a Card for Thailand

Two dated Japan changes worth planning around, one free Thai arrival card worth filing early, and a European biometric wall now fully up.

Japan hands the traveller two firm dates. From 1 October the nationwide Japan Rail Pass rises up to six per cent — the seven-day Ordinary to ¥53,000, the fourteen-day to ¥84,000, the twenty-one-day to ¥105,000 — so a trip anywhere on the horizon is a reason to buy before 30 September and lock the old rate.¹ From 1 November the tax-free system flips: instead of the instant point-of-sale discount, you pay the full ten per cent consumption tax in-store and claim a refund at the airport on departure, settling one to four weeks later by card or bank.¹ A separate report of a higher departure tax could not be corroborated this week and is held rather than printed.¹

For the Grand Tour readers pointing at Chiang Mai, one form matters. Thailand's Digital Arrival Card is free, replaced the old paper slip last year, and must be filed 24 to 72 hours before arrival — and the official portal is the only one, so any site asking for a fee to file it is a scam.² Reports of a mandatory new immigration app landing this month could not be confirmed against the primary source and are flagged, not asserted; the long-mooted 300-baht entry fee is still not in force, so don't build it into the budget.²

THE SCEPTIC · READ THE FINE PRINT

Two traps for the unwary. The Japan refund switch means fronting the cash and waiting weeks for it back — factor it into a big-ticket camera purchase, where the ten per cent is real money held. And every "arrival card" and "entry fee" spawns a fake-portal cottage industry; if a Thailand or Japan site asks for a card number to file a *free* form, close the tab.

IN BRIEF — THE RULEBOOK ELSEWHERE

Europe. The biometric Entry/Exit System reached full operation on 10 April; the €20 ETIAS pre-authorisation is scheduled to launch in the last quarter of 2026, with a grace period after go-live — apply before a spring trip, not at the gate.³

Bali. The one-time IDR 150,000 (~\$13) tourist levy holds; pay online via the official Love Bali portal before arrival and show the QR to skip the airport queue.⁴

The through-line. Every reform this fortnight moves the friction later — refunds at departure, authorisations before you fly, cards filed days ahead. The gate is quieter; the homework is earlier.

The practical upshot for anyone with a Q4 trip on the calendar is a short weekend to-do list: buy the rail pass before the October rise, file the arrival card in the seventy-two-hour window, and check whether the European authorisation has gone live before a spring booking. None of it is onerous; all of it is the kind of thing that ruins a departure hall if left to the day.¹

¥53,000

THE NEW 7-DAY JR PASS FROM 1 OCT — BUY BEFORE 30 SEP
TO LOCK THE OLD RATE

SOURCES 1. japan.travel (JNTO); Euronews Travel (15 Apr 2026) — JR Pass +up to 6% from 1 Oct (7-day ¥53,000; 14-day ¥84,000; 21-day ¥105,000); tax-free → airport-refund from 1 Nov (pay 10%, refund 1–4 wks). ¥3,000 departure-tax report single-sourced — held. 2. Tourism Authority of Thailand; ThaiEmbassy.com — TDAC free, 24–72h pre-arrival, official-portal-only; "THIM app mandatory Aug 2026" single-sourced (flagged); 300-baht fee not in force. 3. EC Migration & Home Affairs (30 Mar 2026) — EES fully operational 10 Apr; ETIAS €20, Q4 2026. 4. Love Bali (baliprov.go.id) — IDR 150k levy.

THE GRAND TOUR · CHIANG MAI, THAILAND

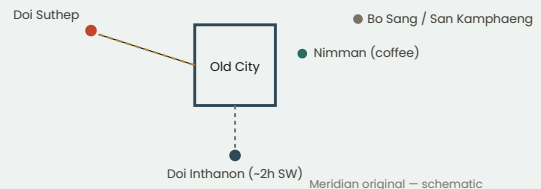
The Lanna City, Read by Its Seasons

A moated old town of three hundred temples, a coffee scene to rival its cafés-per-block, and a calendar with one glorious night and one month to flee. When you go decides everything.

Chiang Mai rewards the reader who reads the calendar first. The best window is the cool-dry season, November to February, when the days are comfortable and the mountains are actually visible.¹ Its signature night is Yi Peng and Loy Krathong, around 24–25 November this year, when candlelit krathong drift on the Ping and sky lanterns rise over the old city — though the mass-release most foreigners photograph is a ticketed event outside town, and repeat visitors often argue the free riverside celebration at Tha Phae Gate is the better picture.¹

The honest warning is the burning season. From February to April, agricultural and forest smoke turns Chiang Mai into one of the most polluted cities on earth — this year the air-quality index hit 263 and the city topped the global rankings, with fine-particulate levels many times the safe guideline.² For a photography-and-child trip, that is a hard no. Mid-August, now, is the opposite: green, cheap, thin crowds, and short afternoon downpours that clear the mornings — an underrated window if you plan the sights before lunch.¹

CHIANG MAI & AROUND



The moated old city, the mountain temple, Nimman's coffee blocks, and the craft road east.

263

AIR-QUALITY INDEX, CHIANG MAI, 29 MAR 2026 — THE BURNING-SEASON REASON TO AVOID FEB–APR

Getting there is the three-hour Scoot nonstop, or a flexible hop via Bangkok on the wider network; fares run budget-direct in green season and climb over Yi Peng — a number this desk will not pin without a live quote.³ The city is small and walkable at its core, which changes the calculus of where to sleep more than the star rating does.

WHERE TO BASE

The Old City — temples on every corner, the Sunday Walking Street, walkable and atmospheric; base near Tha Phae Gate. The trade-off is older, smaller hotels and some tourist-strip noise.⁴

Nimman — the specialty-coffee and design district, trendier and pricier, best for a café-led stay; also the most "could-be-anywhere," which a vocal minority holds against it.⁴

The Ping riverside — leafy and calm, colonial-Lanna character, the quiet-luxe base. On the buy-once hotel: the intimate teak 137 Pillars House and the in-city Anantara on the river are the character picks; the Four Seasons sits grandly out in the Mae Rim valley — a resort you never leave, at the cost of a car to every sight.⁴

SOURCES 1. Festival & season guides (midnightblueelephant; Nomadic Notes) — Nov–Feb window; Yi Peng/Loy Krathong ~24–25 Nov 2026 (ticketed mass-release vs free riverside — verify CAD official date/price); green-season Aug. 2. IQAir newsroom (4 Mar 2026); Open Magazine — 2026 burning-season AQI 263, city topped global rankings; PM2.5 far above WHO guideline. 3. Scoot/aggregators — SIN–CNX ~3h05 nonstop; via Bangkok alternative; fares held indicative. 4. Area/hotel guides (Scott Dunn; 137 Pillars; FlyerTalk) — Old City vs Nimman vs riverside; 137 Pillars/Anantara/Four Seasons; room counts/status to verify.

THE GRAND TOUR · WHAT EARNS THE TRIP

Temples at Dawn, Coffee by Noon, One Honest Bowl

The sights that reward the effort, the elephant question answered plainly, and the khao soi shack that sells out by two.

The set-pieces first. Doi Suthep, the golden mountain-top chedi up its naga staircase, is genuinely worth it and also the most crowded and commercial temple in the region — go at dawn.¹ In town, the ruined Lanna chedi of Wat Chedi Luang and the gilded Wat Phra Singh carry the old city, and both reward an early hour. Doi Inthanon, Thailand's highest peak, is a low-effort full day of waterfalls, cool cloud-forest and Karen coffee villages that suits a child.¹

On the elephants, be plain: no riding, no bathing-for-tourists, no shows. The gold standard is observation-only, and Elephant Nature Park — founded by Lek Chailert — is the name that survives scrutiny; the real hazard is greenwashing, operations with "sanctuary" in the title that still offer rides or forced baths, so read the itinerary, not the branding.² The coffee is the other reason to come: northern Thai arabica grown on the Doi slopes, poured in a Nimman scene with more roasters per block than almost anywhere in the region — the reader's lane, and worth a slow morning.¹

Then the food, which is really one dish and its city. Khao soi — egg noodles in a coconut-curry broth, crisp noodles on top, pickled mustard and shallot and lime — is the thing to seek. The named shack is Khao Soi Khun Yai, on the old city wall between two temples, about 70 baht a bowl, lunch only, and sold out by early afternoon; the Michelin-listed Khao Soi Mae Manee is the sit-down alternative.³ Graze Warorot market and the Sunday Walking Street for the rest — sai ua sausage, the northern chilli dips,

sticky rice. It is cheap by Singapore standards; the splurge is the hotel and the private-car day trips, not daily life, and the baht-to-Singapore-dollar read runs through the Macro desk (p14).³

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE FORUMS ACTUALLY SAY

Three consensuses run through r/chiangmai, r/Thailand and the TripAdvisor board. The loudest, and the one the hard data backs: do not come in burning season. The most heated: elephant ethics, with a firm anti-riding line and open suspicion of "ethical" branding. And the cleanest split — Old City for first-timers and temples, Nimman for coffee and comfort, with a vocal minority calling Nimman "soulless."

r/chiangmai; r/Thailand; TripAdvisor (characterised, not quoted), 2026

THE SCEPTIC · THE POSTCARD IS STAGED

The image of a thousand lanterns rising in unison is mostly a ticketed, staged event outside town, pricey and crowded. The better night is often the free one — krathong on the Ping, lanterns over Tha Phae Gate. And the digital-nomad wave has thinned rather than swelled: the complaint now is less "overrun" than "Westernised in pockets," Nimman especially.⁴

FOR THE ELEVEN-YEAR-OLD

The day that lands: an observation-only elephant sanctuary in the morning, a Lanna cooking class through the afternoon rain, the Sunday Walking Street at dusk. Sights sit close together; short Grab hops cover the gaps.⁵

The craft afternoon: the San Kamphaeng road east to Bo Sang's hand-painted umbrellas and the silk and silver workshops — bought direct from the makers, which is the reader's kind of souvenir.¹

SOURCES 1. Temple/craft/coffee guides (Travel Lemming; Nomadic Notes; Where Goes Rose) — Doi Suthep, Wat Chedi Luang, Wat Phra Singh, Doi Inthanon, Bo Sang/San Kamphaeng, Nimman roasters. 2. elephantnaturepark.org; ethical-sanctuary roundups — observation-only, no-riding; ENP/Lek Chailert; greenwashing caveat. 3. Eating Thai Food; Michelin Guide — khao soi (Khun Yai ~฿70, lunch-only; Mae Manee); Warorot/Sunday Walking Street; cost read; FX cross-ref Macro (p14). 4. Forum synthesis (r/chiangmai, r/Thailand, TripAdvisor) — burning-season, elephant ethics, Old City vs Nimman, staged lantern release, nomad decline. 5. Family-logistics guides — sanctuary/cooking-class/market pacing.

THE DIARY · THE SEASON FILLS UP

What to Book Between Now and the New Year

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

- 9-11 OCT

★ **F1 Singapore GP — the first-ever Sprint**

MARINA BAY · SPRINT QUALIFYING FRI, SPRINT SAT, GP SUN · PADANG CONCERTS ALONGSIDE
- 2-3 OCT

The Weeknd — After Hours Til Dawn

NATIONAL STADIUM · TWO NIGHTS, HIS BIGGEST SG SHOWS
- 17 OCT

BIGBANG — XX: Cosmos, 20th anniversary

NATIONAL STADIUM · DATE SINGLE-SOURCED — CONFIRM WITH LIVE NATION
- 17-22 DEC

★ **BTS — four nights, SOLD OUT**

NATIONAL STADIUM · 17 / 19 / 20 / 22 DEC · OFFICIAL RESALE ONLY
- 4 OCT

Hiroshi Sugimoto — Form Is Emptiness (closes)

SINGAPORE ART MUSEUM · FINAL WEEKS OF THE MASTER'S SHOW
- to 15 NOV

Fear No Power — Women Imagining Otherwise

NATIONAL GALLERY SINGAPORE · MAJOR GROUP EXHIBITION
- 8 NOV

Zai Kuning — We Are Home and Everywhere

OTA FINE ARTS · OPENING-NIGHT PERFORMANCE; A GILLMAN GALLERY CLUSTER
- 4-5 DEC

ZoukOut — the beach festival

SENTOSA · LINEUP ROLLING OUT; THE YEAR-END DANCE ANCHOR
- Dec SEASON

Christmas Wonderland

GARDENS BY THE BAY · LIGHTS, CARNIVAL, FOOD VILLAGE · THE FAMILY ANCHOR

JAPAN & THE REGION

PLAN THE FLIGHTS

- 13-27 SEP

★ **Aki Basho — Grand Sumo, Tokyo**

RYÖGOKU KOKUGIKAN · TICKETS RELEASED 8 AUG; WEEKEND SEATS GO WITHIN HOURS
- 9-10 OCT

★ **Takayama Autumn Festival**

TAKAYAMA, GIFU · UNESCO YATAI FLOATS, LANTERN PROCESSION — THE REGIONAL TRIP
- 22 OCT

Jidai Matsuri — Festival of the Ages

KYOTO · HISTORICAL-COSTUME PROCESSION; KURAMA FIRE FESTIVAL SAME NIGHT
- 18 NOV+ WINDOW

Kōyō — the autumn-leaves window

TOKYO ~18 NOV-EARLY DEC, KYOTO ~23 NOV · PEAKS ~3-5 DAYS LATE THIS YEAR
- open NOW

teamLab — Borderless & Planets

AZABUDAI HILLS & TOYOSU, TOKYO · TIMED-ENTRY, SELLS OUT DAILY
- Sep-Dec AUTUMN

National Art Center, Tokyo

ROPPONGI · AUTUMN LOAN SHOWS — CONFIRM EXACT TITLES/DATES
- 8 NOV

Arashiyama Momiji Festival, Kyoto

DECORATED BOATS ON THE ŌI RIVER · THE FOLIAGE-SEASON OPENER

THE SCEPTIC · ON SOLD-OUT SHOWS

The BTS nights are gone, and premium seats flipped at roughly three times face within an hour of the presale, drawing the authorities' attention. Treat any "guaranteed" ticket outside official resale as a mark. Sumo weekend boxes are the same story in miniature — the queue is the event.¹

PLANNING NOTES

Buy the Aki Basho weekend seats now — the 8 August release is already thin. Lock the F1 Sprint (9-11 Oct) and the Weeknd (2-3 Oct) before the September rush. And for a November Japan run, the koyo peaks three to five days late this year: target Tokyo from 18 Nov, Kyoto from 23 Nov, and book the ryokan first.¹

SOURCES 1. RacingNews365 (F1 Sprint 9-11 Oct); Live Nation SG (BTS 17-22 Dec, sold out; resale ~3× flagged); Urban List/Trip.com (Weeknd 2-3 Oct); Tokyo Cheapo (Aki Basho 13-27 Sep, tickets 8 Aug); MATCHA (Takayama 9-10 Oct); Ocula (SAM Sugimoto to 4 Oct; National Gallery to 15 Nov). BIGBANG date & NACT titles single-sourced — verify.

THE DIARY · THE TABLE

Four New Rooms, One Already Loved

Singapore's fortnight of openings ran from a Blue-Zones glasshouse to a character-branded bakery — and only one has been open long enough to earn a verdict.

The standout is Foura, a 120-seat glasshouse at the entrance to Gardens by the Bay's new IMBA immersive theatre, open since 9 July. The kitchen is built on Blue Zones principles — grass-fed and free-range proteins, omega-rich seafood, high-polyphenol olive oil — organised around four "realms," with yoga and breathwork programming next door.¹ It reads, unusually, as a wellness restaurant that leads with the cooking: reviewers name the Patagonian toothfish (around S\$46, "buttery, clean") and the burratina with pumpkin purée on toasted sourdough (S\$28) unprompted, and the early consensus is warm. Mains run roughly S\$28–46; the golden-hour outdoor tables suit a family.¹

Jiin moves into the former Zeniya premises at Shaw Centre, "retaining everything but the name," with the omakase re-tuned for a bolder palate; lunch from S\$138, dinner from S\$288.² It is too new to call — the coverage so far describes rather than judges, and no reception consensus has formed. Book direct; the counter is small.

The two crowd-pleasers are novelties first. A POP MART-themed bakery-café turns the collectible-character brand into pastries and photo-ops — the draw is the IP and the queue, not yet the crumb, and it is squarely aimed at an eleven-year-old.³ And a conveyor-belt hotpot buffet is running more than a

hundred dishes at S\$22.90++ — the value story of the month, casual, and also too new to judge on the food.³ Both earn a line, not a verdict.

BOOKING THE FORTNIGHT

The method, briefly. The Table rotates rooms each issue and reads the reception before it recommends — food media and the socials both — so a "too new to call" here is a verdict withheld, not a knock.

Still worth the trip. Last fortnight's certified pick, André Chiang's 1887 at Raffles, holds its two-star standing; a settled room beats a launch queue when you actually want dinner.

THE CHATTER · THE VERDICT ON FOURA

The early room is on Foura's side: reviewers frame it as the rare wellness table that leads with the plate, and the toothfish and the burrata-and-pumpkin are the dishes people name without prompting. No dissent of note has surfaced — which is partly a function of how new it is. Call it loved-so-far, not yet stress-tested.

middleclass.sg; The Peak; Tatler Asia, Aug 2026

PLANNING NOTES

Foura and Christmas Wonderland and teamLab all suit the daughter; book the outdoor Foura table at golden hour. On the too-new rooms, give POP MART and the hotpot buffet a fortnight to settle before a special trip — the launch queues are novelty, not a review. Halal status varies; confirm when you book.

BLUE-ZONES DINING

OMAKASE

TOO NEW TO CALL

SOURCES 1. middleclass.sg; The Peak; Tatler Asia — Foura (Gardens by the Bay, opened 9 Jul 2026); Blue-Zones concept; toothfish ~S\$46, burratina S\$28; mains ~S\$28–46. 2. Honeycombers — Jiin omakase (Shaw Centre, ex-Zeniya); lunch from S\$138, dinner from S\$288; too new to judge (single-sourced). 3. Eatbook — POP MART bakery-café; conveyor-belt hotpot buffet at S\$22.90++; both too new to judge (single-sourced). Prices to re-verify against live pages.

THE UNDERCURRENT · TAIWAN

The Girls on the Mound

Taiwan turned baseball into a concert — and then started importing Korea's idols to headline it. For twenty years Asia bought Korean cool. This is the first market to manufacture a version good enough to sell back.

Walk into a Chinese Professional Baseball League game in Taoyuan on a Friday night in 2026 and the first thing you notice is that half the crowd has its back to the field. They are facing a raised platform along the third-base line, where a line of women in team colours leads two and a half hours of synchronised song and choreography. The pitcher throws; the platform performs. In Taiwan's ballparks the baseball has quietly turned into the opening act, and the cheer squad is the headliner.¹

These women — the Rakuten Girls, the Fubon Angels, the Wei Chuan Dragon Beauties — are now among the island's largest pop celebrities, several with followings no player on the roster can match. Lin Hsiang, of the Dragon Beauties, carries some 1.8 million Instagram followers and a cross-over fame in Japan; the squads release singles, front cosmetics campaigns, and sell their own trading cards.² They pull first-time fans through the turnstiles who could not name the starting nine.²

Here is the fact to carry to dinner: the single most valuable free-agent signing in Taiwanese baseball over the last two years was not a slugger or an ace. It was a South Korean cheerleader. Lee Ju-eun, whose "Pikki Pikki" strikeout dance — filmed mid-makeup-touch-up — drew some ninety million views and a global copycat challenge, reportedly moved to Taiwan's Fubon on a deal around 440 million won,

roughly US\$320,000, far above a typical league player's salary.³

The cultural current that for two decades ran one way — Korean idol culture flooding Asia — has, in this one strange niche, reversed. Korea's cheer stars now emigrate to Taiwan for bigger money and bigger stages, and Korean clubs are reportedly discussing how to stop the outflow.³ The inflection is datable: March 2023, when the Rakuten Monkeys signed Lee Da-Hye, the league's first foreign cheerleader — and the attendance moved.⁴

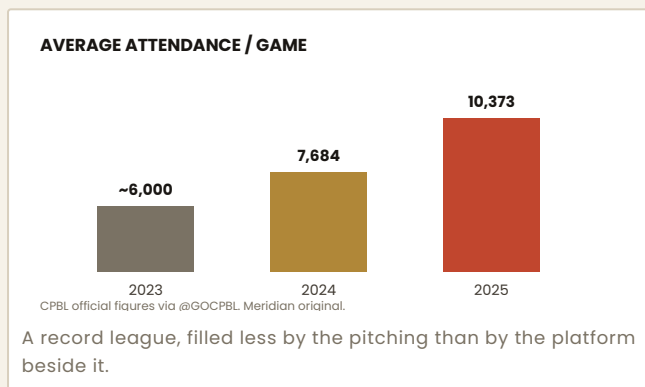
Sit through one and the mechanics are unmistakable. A cheer captain works a raised platform for two and a half hours, leading team-specific chants the whole stand knows by heart; between innings the squad dances, and the jumbotron cuts to them as often as to the dugout. The merchandise follows the faces, not the roster — signed photocards, cosmetics tie-ins, calendars, the same apparatus that sells a K-pop group, pointed at a shortstop's cheer section.² The 2023 World Baseball Classic put that spectacle in front of a global audience for the first time, and the export idea followed almost immediately.¹

The game has become the opening act. The headliner wears pom-poms.

SOURCES 1. "How cheerleading became the 'charging cord' of baseball in Taiwan," MLB.com, 2024; TaiwanPlus, 2025. 2. NamuWiki/social profiles — Lin Hsiang (林襄) ~1.8M Instagram; endorsement/merch/trading-card economy. 3. Korea Times/Korea Herald (2025); Star News Korea (28 Jan 2026) — Lee Ju-eun "Pikki Pikki" (~90M views); Taiwan deal ~440M KRW (≈US\$320k, as reported); Korean-league discussions on limits (reported/contested). 4. Focus Taiwan (CNA), 2023–25 — Lee Da-Hye, first foreign CPBL cheerleader, Mar 2023.

THE UNDERCURRENT · THE NUMBERS, AND THE MEANING

The scale is not a novelty item. The CPBL sold 2.77 million tickets in 2024, averaging 7,684 a game, up about thirty per cent on the year before; in 2025 the average reached roughly 10,373, a league record, with the Fubon Guardians — a club built around its cheer identity — up more than half.¹ An academic paper this year put a coefficient on it: across 1,320 games, each additional foreign cheerleader lifted attendance about four per cent, and Lee Da-Hye alone raised it some thirteen per cent in her first season — before the effect faded toward insignificance, a textbook novelty curve.² Around forty Korean cheerleaders now work across Taiwan's leagues, projected past sixty in 2026.³



10,373

AVERAGE CPBL ATTENDANCE PER GAME IN 2025 — A LEAGUE RECORD, UP ~35%

Why has no one you read written this up? Western general-interest coverage sees Taiwan through two lenses only — semiconductors and the strait — and the stadium idol economy sits outside both. The story lives in sports and trade press, in Taipei and Korean outlets, in one economics journal. No feature

on it exists in the Times, the BBC, Reuters or the FT.⁴ This is the kind of thing those mastheads discover three weeks late.

The obvious read is that sex sells. The truer one is about which economy has colonised the stadium. In an attention market the scarce good is not athletic excellence — Taiwan has always had that — but affection, and the cheer squads monetise it directly, through endorsements and music and merchandise, in a way the athletes structurally cannot.⁵ The idol economy did not build a venue next to the ballpark. It moved inside and took the better seats.

Put it beside the lens the West does use for Taiwan and the omission is almost funny. The semiconductor story is about a scarce physical good the whole world competes for; this is about a scarce emotional one the island learned to manufacture at home. Both are export industries. Only one gets the front page — and it is not the one that just out-bid Seoul for Seoul's own talent.⁴

The academic honesty is worth keeping, too: the cheerleader bump is a novelty effect that decays. The signing lifts the gate hard in year one and fades toward nothing by the third season — which means the clubs are running an escalator, always needing the next face to hold the crowd they bought with the last.² That, not the choreography, is the business model.

The scoreboard still measures runs. The box office now measures follower counts.

SOURCES 1. Taipei Times (28 Mar 2025); CPBL official figures via @GOCPL (Oct 2025) — 2.77M tickets / 7,684 avg (2024); ~10,373 avg (2025 record); Fubon +52.3%. 2. Kuo & Wu, "Stealing the Show? Foreign Cheerleaders and Baseball Fan Attendance in Taiwan's CPBL," *Applied Economics* (2026) — 1,320-game panel; ~4%/cheerleader; ~13% Lee Da-Hye 2023; novelty fade by 2025. 3. Star News Korea (Jan 2026) — ~40 Korean cheerleaders in Taiwan, projected 60+ in 2026. 4. Verified absence of NYT/BBC/Reuters/FT feature (Aug 2026). 5. Taiwan Insight (19 Jun 2026); The Splintering (30 Sep 2025) — the squads "in some ways eclipsed" the sport.

THE UNDERCURRENT · THE REVERSAL

There is a local shape for what has happened. The CPBL stadium has become a modern 廟會 — a temple fair, where the deity's procession is the nominal reason everyone came but the carnival around it is the actual draw. And there is a sharper historical one. Baseball itself was a colonial import, arriving under Japanese rule; the Chiayi KANO team reached the final of Japan's national high-school championship at Kōshien in 1931, and Taiwan inherited the drum-led ōuendan cheering tradition along with the game.¹ Over a century the island took a borrowed ritual and made something entirely its own.

And has begun to export it. The Rakuten Girls have performed at Major League "Taiwan Day" games in the United States; the 2026 World Baseball Classic squad drew six of its members from their ranks.² The thesis worth landing is this: for two decades Asia imported Korean cool, and Taiwan is the first market to manufacture a version good enough to sell back to Seoul. The reported friction — Korean clubs said in January to be weighing limits on their cheerleaders moonlighting abroad, a claim later softened from an outright ban to a discussion — is the tell. You only build a wall around an export you have started to lose.³

You only build a tariff wall around an export you have started to lose.

The unease is Taiwan's own, too. Local commentators debate, half-anxiously, whether the

cheerleaders have eclipsed the sport; Korean fans watch home-grown stars decamp for richer stages with the pride and grievance of a football town losing its academy graduate.⁴ The flip side of the fame is influencer-scale weight — one Taiwanese cheerleader was censured over advertising claims, a reminder that these women now carry commercial and reputational stakes their pom-poms never used to.⁴

Guy Debord saw the shape of it sixty years ago, writing that the spectacle is not a collection of images but a social relation mediated by images — a gathering where the thing everyone came to watch turns out to be each other, watching. The stadium did not stop being about baseball because the cheerleaders arrived; it revealed that it had always been about congregation, and the game was one good excuse among several.

Watch how the local discourse turns on itself and you see a culture arguing with its own success. The commentary is not celebratory so much as uneasy — a low hum of "have we let the sideshow become the show," running alongside the ticket records it can't argue with. That ambivalence is the healthiest thing about it: a scene aware that the thing filling its stadiums is also the thing changing what its stadiums are for.⁴

The runs still count. What changed is where the crowd looks, and what it came to feel. When the FT files this in three weeks, remember which desk brought you to the mound first — with its back, like everyone else's, to the game.

SOURCES 1. Historical: KANO at Kōshien, 1931; baseball under Japanese rule (1895–1945); the ōuendan cheer tradition — standard histories. 2. CPBL Stats/MLB — Rakuten Girls at MLB "Taiwan Day" games; Pacific League news (Feb 2026) — 2026 WBC "CT AMAZE" squad, 6 of the Rakuten Girls. 3. Star News Korea (28 Jan 2026) — Korean-league discussion of limits (reported/contested; "ban" later softened). 4. Taiwan Insight (Jun 2026); Korea Times/Koreaboo (2025); Taiwan News (Feb 2023) — eclipse debate; Korean fan sentiment; a cheerleader censured over ad claims. Quote: Guy Debord, *The Society of the Spectacle* (1967).

The week kept teaching us to look away from the game. In Taiwan's ballparks the crowd turns its back on the pitch to face a platform of dancers, and the baseball becomes the pretext for the gathering. In the card trade the value migrates off the card and into the plastic slab around it — a grade, a number, a thing about the thing. Even a new desk earns its debut by insisting on the harder discipline: not the label, the cloth. There is nothing hollow in any of it. A crowd that came for the cheer squad still came together; a collector who prices the grade still loves the card. Debord's warning was never that spectacle is fake, only that it is a relationship — that what we assemble to watch is, in the end, each other. Look away from the game, and you find the people. That is not the loss. That was always the point.

— THE DESK, NO. 74

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES

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